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Reading Reflection 3

When reading this text, the main idea I took away is that prototypes aren't just tools for testing whether a design works or fails. Lim, Stolterman and Tenenberg argue that prototypes are how designers explore, learn and come up with new ideas, and they propose an "anatomy of prototypes" to describe what a prototype actually is. Overall, I thought it was a good reading.

The first part of their anatomy is prototypes as filters. A prototype is always incomplete, and that's actually its strength, because what it leaves out matters as much as what it includes. The authors name five things a prototype can focus on: appearance, data, functionality, interactivity and spatial structure. The second part is prototypes as manifestations, which is about how a prototype is made: its material, its level of detail and how much of the design it covers.

The case studies showed how much this matters. In the house study, people who saw a 2D blueprint talked about layout, while people who walked through a 3D model talked about how it felt. In the phone study, the same feature was tested three ways and only 20% of the findings matched. So the way a prototype is made changes what people notice.

This made me think about my own work in UX. Sometimes you just go with your own ideas, and a lot of the time I've designed based on patterns I already know, without necessarily understanding the user the best. Testing with users is what helps us actually understand them better, which is exactly why prototypes are so important.

I also related to the part about digital material being a "material without qualities." Since I design on Figma, the design is basically limitless, but actually producing that design sometimes has limits. That gap between what's possible in a prototype and what's possible in the final product is something the authors point out too, since a prototype is never the same as the final design. I think that's what makes prototyping so interesting.